

IT IS TIME TO PROCLAIM MIRACLES, SIGNS, AND WONDERS

TEXT: Acts 2:22–24 (NKJV) *“Men of Israel, hear these words: Jesus of Nazareth, a Man attested by God to you by miracles, wonders, and signs which God did through Him in your midst, as you yourselves also know— 23 Him, being delivered by the determined purpose and foreknowledge of God, you have taken by lawless hands, have crucified, and put to death; 24 whom God raised up, having loosed the pains of death, because it was not possible that He should be held by it.”*

INTRO: Our text is an excerpt from the first evangelistic/Pentecostal message ever preached. It is here that the Apostle Peter introduced Jesus of Nazareth as the Son of God, the Messiah, with the words, *“a Man attested by God to you by miracles, wonders, and signs which God did through Him in your midst, as you yourselves also know.”*

The Greek word translated “*attest*” here, means “*to cause something to be known as genuine, to make clearly known.*”

Jesus Christ ministered to the people for three and a half years, teaching them about God, thus proclaiming the Good News. But it was the miracles, signs, and wonders that proved who He was, and that His message was genuine. John 7:31 (NKJV) “*And many of the people believed in Him, and said, “When the Christ comes, will He do more signs than these which this Man has done?”*”

The miracles, signs, and wonders that were features of Jesus ministry caused the people to ask, “*When the Christ comes, will He do more signs than these which this Man has done?*” Please notice, the message was not the miracles, signs, and wonders, but they were the things God employed to prove the genuineness of Jesus’ message, and to confirm that He was in fact the One they had been waiting for. The

miracles, signs, and wonders proved Him to be the Son of God, the Messiah, their Savior.

While we are going to focus on miracles, signs and wonders today, and you will be hearing a lot about this in the coming year, the message cannot be miracles, signs and wonders – the message is Jesus. However, the proof that we are who we say we are, and the proof that our message is true is miracles, signs, and wonders.

DEFINITION OF MIRACLES, SIGNS AND WONDERS

These three words, “*Miracles, Signs and Wonders*” are frequently found together in the New Testament.

The meanings of these three words are different, but because they are so often used together, sometimes people mistakenly believe their meanings are interchangeable, and that they are one and the same.

“Miracles, Signs, and Wonders” speak about three different aspects of the nature and power of God. While the function of these three words are complementary, together they bring about the full impact of who God is, and what He does.

The Greek word translated as ***“miracles”*** is (δύναμις) *dunamis*, and it means *“a deed manifesting great power with the implication of some supernatural force.”* Oftentimes we find it translated in the New Testament as ***“power, mighty works, and strength.”***

From the Greek word (δύναμις) *dunamis*, we get our English word dynamite. The miracle working power of God shows His mighty hand, and his enormous power.

The Greek word translated as ***“sign”*** is (σημεῖον) *semeion*, and it means *“a sign, a mark; by which a person or thing is distinguished from others and is known; an event which is regarded as having some special*

meaning; not simply a miraculous event but something which points to a reality of even greater significance. ”

The concept of the word “**sign**” means much more than a symbol. The word embodies a sense of something unique in what it points to, so that there is no ambiguity in what is being represented.

The Greek word translated as “**wonder**” is (τέρας) teras, and it means “*a marvel.*” It speaks to the wonder or awe that is produced in those who witness the miracle, or the dunamis.

Therefore:

- A miracle is the supernatural power of God being manifest in the natural realm...
- A sign points up the fact that no one but God could have done such a thing...

- A wonder is the awe that is produced in the hearts of the people as they witness the miracle...

All three together, miracles, signs, and wonders give a complete revelation of the supernatural power of God and are utilized in turning our hearts, and the hearts of others to God. (Story of Tanaya in India – God raised the child to life (Miracle) – There was no doubting who was at work (Sign) – The hearts of the people were turned to God (Wonder).

THE PROOF IS IN THE PUDDIN

Jesus made a bold statement in John 10:37–39 (NKJV) *“If I do not do the works of My Father, do not believe Me; 38 but if I do, though you do not believe Me, believe the works, that you may know and believe that the Father is in Me, and I in Him.”* This bold statement was predicated on the authenticity of Jesus ministry to do miracles, signs and wonders! He was telling them to watch His ministry and if He produced miracles, signs and

wonders, then He was to be believed – If He did not produce miracles, signs and wonders, then He was not to be believed.

Miracles, signs and wonders would be the acid test of whether He had a supernatural order of ministry that went beyond the dead, ritualistic, stagnate, ministry seen in the normal synagogue.

Friends, I believe this is also going to be the test of the modern-day-church! If we have miracles, signs, and wonders then we are to be believed and followed – If not we are not to be believed and followed.

There are two extremes in the Body of Christ; one says God no longer heals and does miracles - The other extreme focuses on the miraculous exclusively, as if the miracles themselves are the message. We believe in miracles, signs and wonders, but rather than seeking the miracles we are seeking the miracle worker. When we embrace the miracle worker and expect Him to

confirm His Word with signs following, we receive what we are believing for. 2 Corinthians 12:12 (NKJV) ***“Truly the signs of an apostle were accomplished among you with all perseverance, in signs and wonders and mighty deeds.”*** The signs of an apostle were manifest in Paul’s life and ministry, not only through the miraculous, but through his godly character, as he ministered to them with ***“all perseverance and patience”***.

Yet, Paul admonishes the Corinthian Christians... 1 Corinthians 2:4–5 (NKJV) ***“My speech and my preaching were not with persuasive words of human wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power, 5 that your faith should not be in the wisdom of men but in the power of God.”***

Miracles, signs, and wonders were an important part of Paul’s ministry, so the people’s faith was not based on ***“persuasive words of human***

wisdom,” but by bringing them to a place of personally encountering the power of God.

THE COUNTERFEIT

The devil’s crowd can do miracles too! So what’s the difference? 2 Thessalonians 2:8–9 (NKJV) “*And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord will consume with the breath of His mouth and destroy with the brightness of His coming. 9 The coming of the lawless one is according to the working of Satan, with all power, signs, and lying wonders.*” The antichrist, by the power of Satan, will be working miracles, signs, and lying wonders! Because of this, he will deceive a great part of the world.

People who are involved in the occult or witchcraft can sometimes testify to “*supernatural*” things happening.

It is interesting that the Word does not say “*lying signs,*” but “*lying wonders.*” It says,

“lying wonders,” because the people will be fooled and deceived by a false awe. People are awestruck because:

- A witch and make a table levitate...
- A soothsayer can accurately predict certain events...
- A psychic can peer into the future... (I thought someone should have seen the bankruptcy of the psychics network happening before it occurred)

People who have been captivated and deceived by demonic entities are drawn to, and awed by, the false miracles of Satan. But the godly are repulsed by them.

If one is spiritually discerning and Biblically astute, they can spot the difference between *“lying signs”* and true signs. Matthew 7:17-18 *“Every good tree bears good fruit, but a bad tree bears bad fruit. A good tree cannot bear bad fruit, nor can a bad tree bear good fruit.”*

Since a sign always reveals the very nature of the source of the miracles, those who follow after demonic miracles, and are awed by them, are normally racked with fear, confusion, anger, perversion, bondage and self-destructive behaviors.

THE GENUINE

Good signs... Acts 8:5–13 (NKJV) *“Then Philip went down to the city of Samaria and preached Christ to them. 6 And the multitudes with one accord heeded the things spoken by Philip, hearing and seeing the miracles which he did. 7 For unclean spirits, crying with a loud voice, came out of many who were possessed; and many who were paralyzed and lame were healed. 8 And there was great joy in that city. 9 But there was a certain man called Simon, who previously practiced sorcery in the city and astonished the people of Samaria, claiming that he was someone great, 10 to whom they all gave heed, from the least to the greatest, saying, “This man is the great power*

of God.”11 And they heeded him because he had astonished them with his sorceries for a long time.12 But when they believed Philip as he preached the things concerning the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, both men and women were baptized.13 Then Simon himself also believed; and when he was baptized he continued with Philip, and was amazed, seeing the miracles and signs which were done.”

Acts, Chapter 8, provides a clear and stark contrast between the signs produced by the Holy Spirit and those produced by Satan.

Simon the sorcerer had been performing miracles for a long time in Samaria. In so doing, he had convinced all the people that he was operating in *“the great power of God.”* Then Philip came to this same city, and began to preach the Gospel and performed miracles. He healed the sick and cast out demons.

What is noteworthy in this story is that once Philip arrived and began to minister by the power of the Holy Spirit and preach the Gospel, the entire population of the city, including Simon, believed his message.

Both Simon and Philip performed miracles, so how was it that no one questioned which of the two was right? Everyone immediately knew they had been deceived by Simon's miracles and that Philip's message, ministry, and miracles were true.

The key to distinguishing between one operating by the power of the Holy Spirit, and one operating by demonic powers, is found in the signs.

“He (Simon) had astonished them with his sorceries for a long time” – The only thing Simon's ministry produced was that the people were astonished by the miracles. They had no other effect. (The devil can do supernatural

things – Only God can bless us – The devil cannot curse what God has blessed)

In contrast to Simon's ministry, the signs of Philip's ministry were *“unclean spirits, crying with a loud voice, coming out of many who were possessed; and many who were paralyzed and lame, being healed,”* and *“there was great joy in that city.”*

Philip's ministry produced freedom, changed lives, and brought great joy. Simon's actions did not change lives for the better, but produced fear and uncertainty, as the people looked on at his miracles. As the King James translation puts it, *“He bewitched the people.”*

Those involved in the occult, witchcraft, horoscopes, séances, ouija boards, and other demonic practices, who try to find out about, or manipulate the future, experience fear, foreboding, and uncertainty. In contrast, those led by the Holy Spirit and the gifts of the Spirit, experience wonderful peace, confidence, joy,

and an unshakeable assurance in the one and only true God, who alone holds the future.

THE CALLING CARD OF AUTHENTICITY

Mark 16:17–20 (NKJV) *“And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues; 18 they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover.” 19 So then, after the Lord had spoken to them, He was received up into heaven, and sat down at the right hand of God. 20 And they went out and preached everywhere, the Lord working with them and confirming the word through the accompanying signs. Amen.”*

The Gospel of Mark concludes by listing the five signs that are to follow or accompany believers:

- Demons cast out... (Britt Brooks, *“I know who you are”*)
- Speak with new tongues... (The language of Heaven – The Old Pasadena First Assembly a Hebrew man was told his family name and his name in perfect Hebrew – The man who spoke the perfect Hebrew had never learned Hebrew)
- Take up serpents... (Authority over the power of the enemy – Kulman Lackey – *“No power greater than Gods power.”*)
- Drink any deadly thing... (Living behind the blood line – What would have killed others didn’t hurt us!)
- Lay hands on the sick and they shall recover... (Have everyone to stand that has had a miracle)

CONCLUSION:

These signs are important, because they are meant to confirm the message of the Gospel.

Miracles and signs do not guarantee that everyone will believe that Jesus Christ is the

Son of God but it does mean they have come face to face with the power of God, and that they now have a choice to either believe in Him or reject Him.

What will we do? We are going to DECLARE MIRACLES, SIGNS AND WONDERS over this place for the year 2020!